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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



AI

AUTOMATION AND THE FUTURE OF ROLES

Who does the work tasks in 2030, which skills rise, which tasks machines take, who bears the change, how much of a role a computer could do, and a card for the tasks of a role.

22% of today's formal jobs are expected to be created or displaced between 2025 and 2030, by employers' forecasts.

WORLD ECONOMIC FORUM, 2025

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Automation rarely removes a whole job at once. It takes over tasks, and the role around them changes. Which tasks move, which skills rise, and what can the manager of a warehouse, delivery or hotel team do?

Employers surveyed by the World Economic Forum expect people alone to do a third of work tasks by 2030, down from 47%, and count AI, leadership and talent management among the skills on the rise. A 2003 study shows which tasks computers take: those that follow explicit rules. In Germany, robots hit new entrants rather than the workers already in place, and a 2026 US study sees a similar pattern with AI. The IAB finds that a computer could do 61% of the core tasks in transport and logistics.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

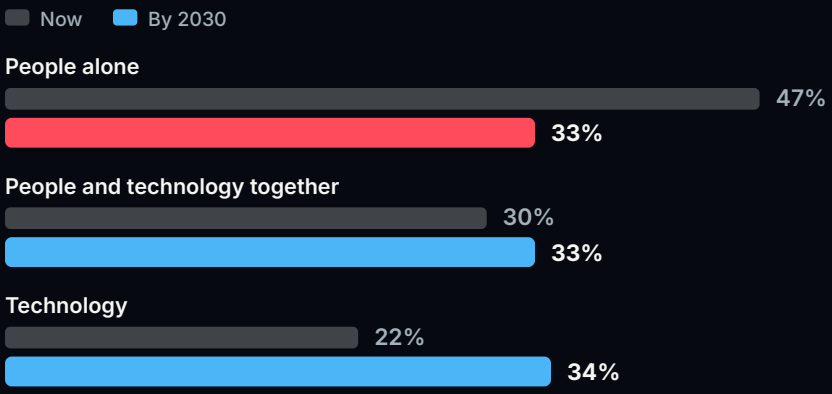
Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

A third each by 2030

For its Future of Jobs Report 2025, the World Economic Forum asked more than 1,000 employers, with over 14 million workers in 55 economies, who does the work tasks today and who will do them in 2030: people, technology, or the two together.

SHARE OF WORK TASKS DONE MAINLY BY…, EMPLOYERS' ESTIMATES



Employers expect 170 million jobs to be created and 92 million displaced by 2030, a churn of 22% of 1.2 billion formal jobs. Delivery drivers and general and operations managers are among the roles growing most in numbers; stock-keeping clerks, cashiers, cleaners and housekeepers among those shrinking most.

OUR READING

The forecast is less about jobs that vanish than about the same jobs done with a different mix of tasks.

Source: World Economic Forum, 2025

These are employers' expectations, not measurements, and shares of tasks, not of the amount of work. The net gain is 78 million jobs. 47 + 30 + 22 = 99 because of rounding.

THE NUMBERS

The skills on the rise

The same employers said which skills will matter more or less by 2030. The net figure is the share expecting a skill to grow minus the share expecting it to shrink.

SKILLS GROWING IN IMPORTANCE, 2025–2030, NET SHARE OF EMPLOYERS (POINTS)



Only two skills fall on balance, most of all manual dexterity, endurance and precision (−24). Of every 100 workers, 59 would need training by 2030: 29 could be upskilled in their role, 19 moved to another role, and 11 would probably not get the training they need.

OUR READING

Next to technology, leadership and talent management rise almost as fast. Someone has to rebuild the team around the new tasks.

Source: World Economic Forum, 2025

Employers' expectations (Future of Jobs Survey 2024), not measurements of skills. The six of 26 skills shown are our choice.

THE MODEL

Which tasks machines take

In 2003 David Autor, Frank Levy and Richard Murnane argued that computers substitute for people in tasks that can be done by following explicit rules, and complement them in non-routine problem-solving and complex communication.

FOLLOWS EXPLICIT RULES

Routine manual
Picking or sorting, repetitive assembly. Substantial substitution.
RULE-BASED · MANUAL

Routine cognitive
Record-keeping, calculation, repetitive customer service. Substantial substitution.
RULE-BASED · ANALYTIC

Non-routine manual
Janitorial work, truck driving. Little substitution or support.
NO FIXED RULE · MANUAL

Non-routine cognitive
Testing ideas, selling, managing others. Strong complementarity.
NO FIXED RULE · ANALYTIC

MANUAL TO ANALYTIC WORK

US data for 1960–1998 link computerisation with less routine and more non-routine cognitive work, even within the same occupations. In 2023 the OECD saw the same with AI: employers were about twice as likely to say AI had automated repetitive tasks as created them.

OUR READING

For a team, the useful question is which tasks of a job follow a rule a machine can read.

Sources: David H. Autor, Frank Levy & Richard J. Murnane, The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2003; OECD, 2023

Examples and effects are those of the 2003 study, written for computers before generative AI.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Who bears the change

Wolfgang Dauth and colleagues followed German workers from 1994 to 2014, as robots spread through industry. Robots cost manufacturing jobs; new service jobs fully offset them.

01

Germany, robots

Workers in place mostly stayed and took on new tasks in the same plant. Young entrants bore the loss.

02

US, robots

Each extra robot per 1,000 workers cut the employment-to-population ratio by 0.2 percentage points and wages by 0.42%.

03

US, AI, 2026

Employment of 22- to 25-year-olds in AI-exposed jobs is 19% behind the path of less exposed peers, mostly through less hiring.

In the OECD's 2022 surveys and interviews, many early AI adopters seemed to adjust through slower hiring, quits and retirement rather than dismissals. Where firms consulted them, workers were 9 points more likely to say AI had improved their health and safety.

OUR READING

The change shows first in the role that is never posted. For the team already there, it shows as new tasks, and someone has to teach them.

Sources: Wolfgang Dauth, Sebastian Findeisen, Jens Suedekum & Nicole Woessner, Journal of the European Economic Association, 2021; Daron Acemoglu & Pascual Restrepo, Journal of Political Economy, 2020; Erik Brynjolfsson, Bharat Chandar & Ruyu Chen, Stanford Digital Economy Lab, 2026; OECD, 2023

Robots in industry are not AI in services, and the Germany–US gap has several possible causes. The 2026 figures and the OECD link are correlations, not proof of cause.

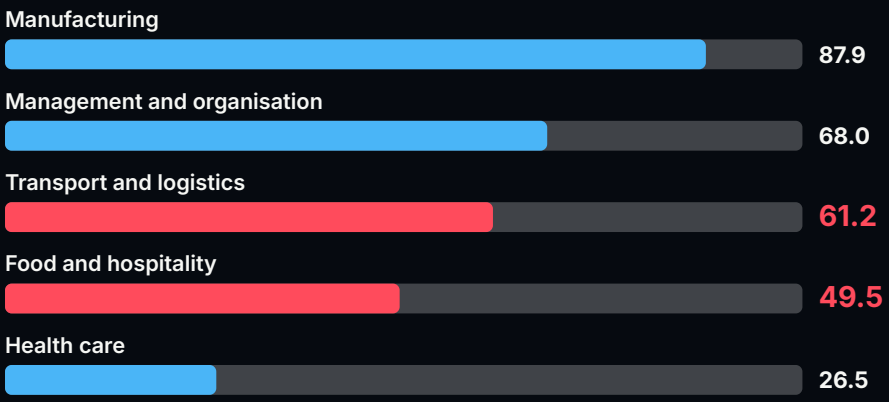
More in the essay “Watch how I do it” is not training

HOW IT IS MEASURED

How much of a role a computer could do

Since 2013 the IAB, research institute of Germany's Federal Employment Agency, has asked of each core task of every occupation: could a computer or computer-controlled machine do it fully automatically? Their share is the substitution potential.

CORE TASKS A COMPUTER COULD DO, GERMANY, 2022 (%)



In 2022, 38% of employees subject to social insurance worked in occupations where over 70% of core tasks could be automated (34% in 2019). For hotel management assistants, the share rose from 50% to 67%.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A DELIVERY-STATION DISPATCHER

Core tasks	10; a system could do 4 in full: 40%
Hours	the 4 take 22 of 40 weekly hours: 55%

Both the role and its hours are made up.

Source: Katharina Grienberger, Britta Matthes & Wiebke Paulus, IAB, 2024

Technical feasibility, not a forecast of job losses. The IAB weights core tasks equally, blind to their hours; the example shows why hours matter.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The task card of a role

One card per role, filled in with the people who do it. List the tasks with their hours a week, then sort them: a few tasks usually take most of the time, and that is where to look first.

01 Role the role, how many people do it, who filled in the card

02 Tasks and hours every core task, hours a week, the largest first

03 Rule or judgement does it follow an explicit rule? manual or analytic?

04 What a machine could do in full, in part or not at all, and with which system

05 What the person does instead the new task, or what the freed hours go to

06 Skill and training what to learn, who teaches it, by when; who on the team was asked

Sources: David H. Autor, Frank Levy & Richard J. Murnane, The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2003; Katharina Grienberger, Britta Matthes & Wiebke Paulus, IAB, 2024; OECD, 2023

A practice proposed by the editors, after the task model of Autor, Levy & Murnane (2003), the IAB method (2024) and the OECD finding that outcomes are better where workers are trained and consulted (2023).

Open the tool: Pareto 80/20 stivencatalyst.com/tools/pareto/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The Future of Jobs Report 2025
World Economic Forum, 2025
https://reports.weforum.org/docs/WEF_Future_of_Jobs_Report_2025.pdf

The Skill Content of Recent Technological Change: An Empirical Exploration
David H. Autor, Frank Levy & Richard J. Murnane, The Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2003
https://doi.org/10.1162/003355303322552801

OECD Employment Outlook 2023: Artificial Intelligence and the Labour Market
OECD, 2023
https://doi.org/10.1787/08785bba-en

The Adjustment of Labor Markets to Robots
Wolfgang Dauth, Sebastian Findeisen, Jens Suedekum & Nicole Woessner, Journal of the European Economic Association, 2021
https://doi.org/10.1093/jeea/jvab012

Robots and Jobs: Evidence from US Labor Markets
Daron Acemoglu & Pascual Restrepo, Journal of Political Economy, 2020
https://doi.org/10.1086/705716

Canaries in the Coal Mine? Six Facts about the Recent Employment Effects of Artificial Intelligence (revised August 2026)
Erik Brynjolfsson, Bharat Chandar & Ruyu Chen, Stanford Digital Economy Lab, 2026
https://digitaleconomy.stanford.edu/publications/canaries-in-the-coal-mine/

Folgen des technologischen Wandels für den Arbeitsmarkt: Vor allem Hochqualifizierte bekommen die Digitalisierung verstärkt zu spüren (IAB-Kurzbericht 5/2024)
Katharina Grienberger, Britta Matthes & Wiebke Paulus, IAB, 2024
https://doku.iab.de/kurzber/2024/kb2024-05.pdf

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

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